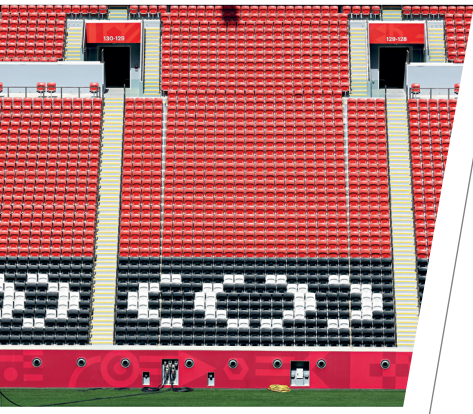





and the conservative culture could potentially be at odds with the rather more relaxed, free-spirited behaviour that football fans are traditionally identified with. For instance, the Emir of Qatar offered an oblique reassurance that gay fans would be welcome despite his kingdom's laws against homosexuality—and went on to ask visitors to "respect our culture". The guidelines for alcohol have been relaxed, with stadiums allowed to serve.

"I'm assuming they are going to loosen up," says Basu. He is keen on the experience of it all, citing the Rugby World Cup in Japan (2019). His son went for it without having arranged for tickets, and still ended up having a blast thanks to the general buzz everywhere, with packed streets and cramped bars. That's the thing about World Cups. It's a global spectacle, held once every four years, with the eyes of the whole world watching. ■

**- Akhil Sood**

INTERVIEW

# THE GOAL OF HAPPINESS

***Sunil Chhetri,** 37, reflects on India's AFC Asian Cup qualification campaign, the spirited youngsters on his squad and on what keeps him ticking after all these years*

**Q. What has gone right for the team during this campaign?**
Everything went right—from the way we prepared at camp before the tournament, the crowds that poured into Kolkata during every game and the football, which has been really enjoyable. This campaign had everything. Even the grit and the fight that the team showed in the game against Afghanistan was incredible.




PTI

"I'm just happy finding the back of the net every time. And every single game is an opportunity to do the same—it's what keeps me going"

**Q. What do you make of the youngsters on the team?**
I'm really pleased with the youngsters and the way they've turned up at the qualifiers. I've always been encouraged by the presence of youngsters who have come through in the last couple of years. The biggest thing is that they play without any pressure of playing for the senior Indian national team. And they express themselves so freely, which is impressive, but also beneficial to the team.

**Q. What has been the Indian Super League's (ISL) contribution when it comes to readying the younger lads for international duty?**
A lot of youngsters have been able to get chances in the ISL. You've seen Naorem Roshan Singh perform really well for Bengaluru FC—seven assists and a goal this season saw him get a national team call-up. You also had the young kids from Hyderabad FC and guys like Liston Colaco from ATK-Mohun Bagan FC get their due. The credit for this goes to coach Igor Stimac.

**Q. You cannot seem to stop scoring. How do you keep the hunger alive after achieving everything that you have?**
I'm just happy doing it, finding the back of the net every time. And every single game is an opportunity to do the same—it's what keeps me going. I haven't been chasing any numbers or records. It's just the happiness that comes from turning up for the team and scoring goals.

**Q. What are some of the changes that you've had to make to your game with age?**
Not much has changed with respect to my game. But there have been changes in my lifestyle—changes to my diet, the way I work out. I am constantly reading up more, understanding things more. I know I am not getting any younger, so the past few years have been about making the right choices. There has been a lot of self-scrutiny and that is helping yield the results that I want. More than changes to my game, it is the changes to the things that I do before the game that has made the difference. ■

**—with Shail Desai**